The Martyrdom of Andy

By Ben Burton

Andy was a sweet, amusing little guy whom everyone liked yet harassed just because that was the way one treated Andy Drake. He took the kidding well. Andy always smiled back with those great big eyes that seemed to say, "Thank you, thank you, thank you," with each sweeping blink.

INTRODUCTION

In recent years, bullying and harassment have been grabbing headlines, creating greater awareness. But there's a dehumanizing experience that is just as common, perhaps even more damaging, and far less well-understood – Ostracism.

It's a form of social rejection that goes by many names and comes in many flavors. Some call it the "social death penalty." Whatever you call it, ostracism is a ghastly form of hurt.

You might think bullying is worse than ostracism, but recent research suggests that being frozen out is actually more painful. It is deeply connected to our most fundamental human need to be recognized and accepted. Ostracism can reshape the human brain.

Ben Burton in his confession entitled "The Martyrdom of Andy" recalls his involvement in the exclusion of classmate named Andy and his understanding and remorse as an adult of how he once behaved.

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For us fifth graders, Andy was our outlet; he was our whipping boy. He even seemed grateful to pay this special price for membership in our group.

"Andy Drake don't eat no cake,
And his sister don't eat no pie.
If it wasn't for the welfare dole,
All the Drakes would die."

Andy even appeared to appreciate this sing-song parody of Jack Spratt. The rest of us really enjoyed it, gad grammar and all. I do not know why Andy had to endure this special treatment to deserve our friendship and membership in the group. It just evolved naturally – no plan or discussion.

I don't recall anyone ever mentioning in this connection that Andy's father was in prison; or that his

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mother took in washing and men,; or that Andy's ankles, elbows and fingernails were always dirty and his old coat was way to big. We soon wore all the fun out of those. Andy never fought back.

Snobbery blossoms in the very young, I guess. It is plain now that the group attitude was that it was our right to belong, but that Andy was a member of our sufferance. Despite all that, we all liked Andy until that day – until that very moment.

"He's different! We don't want him, do we?"

Which one of us said it? I have wanted to blame Randolph all these years. But, I cannot honestly say who spoke those trigger words that brought out the savagery lying dormant but so near the surface in all of us. It doesn't matter who, for the fervor with which we took up the cause revealed us all.

"But I didn't want to do what we did." For years I tried to console myself with that. Then one day I stumbled on the unwelcome but irrefutable words that convicted me forever: "The hottest corners of hell are reserved for those who, during a moment of crisis,

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maintain their neutrality."

The weekend was to be like others the group had enjoyed together. After school on a Friday we would meet at the home of one of the members – mine this time – for a campout in the nearby woods. Our respective mothers, who did most of the preparation for these safaris, fixed an extra pack for Andy who was to join us after chores.

We quickly made camp, mothers' apron strings forgotten. With individual courage amplified by the group, we were now "men against the jungle." The others decided that since it was my party, I should be the one to give Andy the news.

I? I, who had long believed that Andy secretly thought a little more of me than he did the others because of the puppy-like way he looked at me? I who often felt Andy revealing his love and appreciation with those huge, wide-open eyes? I can still plainly see Andy as he came toward me down the long, dark tunnel of trees that leaked only enough of the late afternoon light to kaleidoscope changing patterns on his soiled old

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sweatshirt.

Andy was on his rusty, one-of-a-kind bike – a girl's model with sections of garden hose wired to the rims for tires. He appeared excited and happier than I had ever seen him, this frail little guy who had been an adult all his life. I knew he was savoring the acceptance by the In-group; this first chance to belong, to have boy fun, to do boy things.

Andy waved to me as I stood in the camp clearing awaiting him. I ignored his happy greeting. He vaulted off the funny old bike and trotted over toward me, full of joy and conversation. The others, concealed in the tent, were silent but I felt their support.

Why won't he get serious? Can't he see that I am not returning his cheer? Can't he see by now that his euphoria is not reaching me? Then, suddenly, he did see. His innocent countenance opened even more, leaving him entirely vulnerable. His whole demeanor said, "It is going to be very bad, isn't it, Ben? Let's have it."

Well-practiced in facing disappointment, he didn't even brace for the blow. Andy never fought back.

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Incredulously, I heard myself say, "Andy, we don't want you."

Hauntingly vivid still is the stunning quickness with which two huge tears sprang into Andy's eyes and just stayed there; vivid because of a million maddening reruns of that scene in my mind. The way Andy looked at me – frozen for an eternal moment. What was it? It wasn't hate. Was it shock? Was it disbelief, Or, was it pitty -- for me?

Or forgiveness?

Finally a fleet little tremor broke across Andy's lips and he turned without appeal, or even a question, to make the long, lonely trip back home in the dark. As I turned and entered the tent, someone—the last one of us to feel the full weight of the moment – started the old doggerel:

"Andy Drake don't eat no cake,

And his sister . . . . . "

Then is was unanimous. No vote taken, no word spoken, but we all knew we had done something horribly, cruelly wrong. We were swept over by the delayed

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impact of dozens of lessons and sermons. Each of us heard perhaps for the first time, "Inasmuch as ye do it unto the least of these . . . . "

In that long, hushed heavy moment we gained an understanding new to us then but indelibly fixed in our minds. We had destroyed an individual made in the image of God with the only weapon for which he had no defense, and we had no excuse, rejection.

Andy's poor attendance in school made it difficult to tell when he actually withdrew, but one day it dawned on me that he was gone forever. I had spent too many days struggling within myself to find and to polish a proper way of telling Andy how witheringly ashamed and sorry I was, and am. I now know that to have hugged Andy and to have cried with him and even to have joined with him in a long silence would have been enough. It may have healed us both.

I never saw Andy Drake again. I have no idea where he went or where he is, if he is. But to say I haven't seen Andy is not entirely accurate. In the decades since that autumn day in the Arkansas woods – I

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have encountered thousands of Andy Drakes. My conscience places Andy's mask over the face of every disadvantaged person with whom I come in contact. Each stares back at me with the same haunting and expectant look, which became fixed in my mind that day long ago.

Dear Andy Drake,

The chance you will ever see these words is quite remote, but I must try. It is much too late for this confession to purge my conscience of guilt. I neither expect nor want it to. What I do pray for, my little friend of long ago, is that you might somehow learn of, and be lifted by knowing of, the continuing force of your sacrifice. What you suffered at my hands that dreadful day, and the grace you showed in response, has been twisted, turned and molded by God into a blessing. I hope this knowledge might ease the memory of that terrible day for you.

I have been no saint, Andy, nor have I done

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all the things I could and should have done with my life. But what I yearn for you to know is that I have never again knowingly betrayed an Andy Drake. Nor, I pray, shall I ever.

Love,

Ben

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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